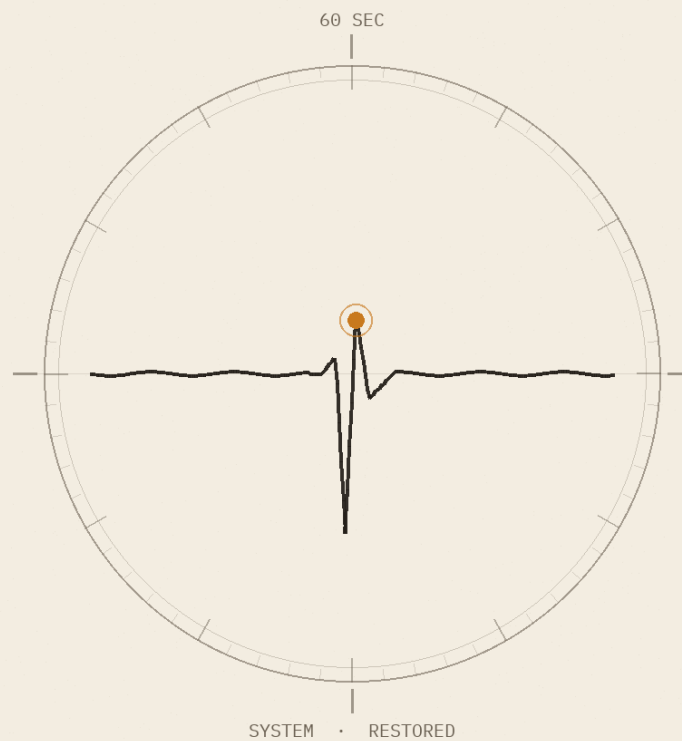


The AIV Recovery Field Manual

BOOK ONE: **The Engine**

*a practical survival guide for healing
the hardware first*



MT

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START HERE

The AIV Recovery Field Manual

Book One: The Engine — a practical survival guide for healing the hardware first.

Hey. Before anything else — I'm not a drill instructor and this isn't a program where you show up and get yelled at until you're fixed. I'm just a guy who spent thirty years in the exact trench you might be standing in right now, and a few years on the other side of it, sitting with a lot of other people still finding their way out.

Here's the one idea I want you to walk away with from this whole book: addiction is not a character flaw. It's not proof you're weak, or broken, or missing whatever gene other people got. It's a system infection — I call it the **Addiction Intelligence Virus (AIV)** — that hijacks the same reward wiring every single human being is born with. Alcohol. A pill. A phone. A bet. A bag. A shopping cart. Ten known vectors, one shared operating system underneath, and none of them make you a worse person for having caught it.

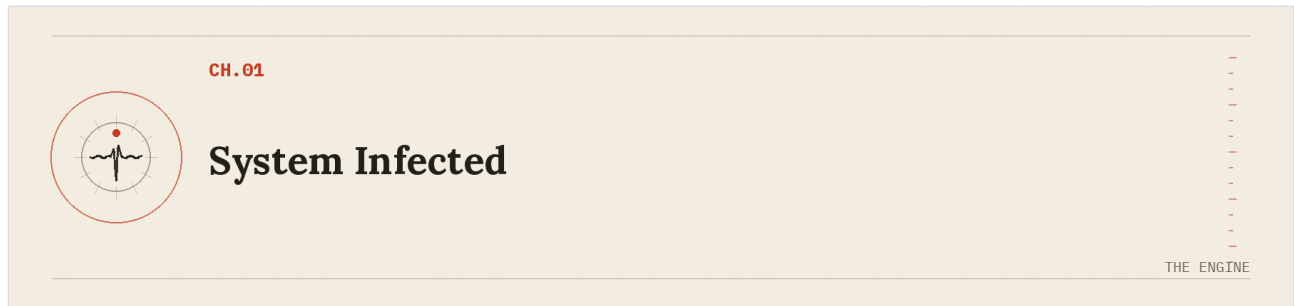
Why this book starts with the body. Real recovery, the way I've built it, leans on three pillars: **The Network** (the human side — sponsorship, meetings, the 12 Steps), **The Engine** (biology — sleep, movement, nutrition, breath), and **The Mirror** (telemetry — your daily log, and how you use it, including AI, to see your own patterns). This manual is **Book One: The Engine**. We start here on purpose — you cannot think, pray, or fellowship your way out of a nervous system that's running on fumes. Fix the hardware first. Books Two and Three will pick up The Network and The Mirror in full.

This manual is my attempt to hand you what I wish someone had handed me — not a lecture, a field guide. Understand what's actually happening in your body, get some tools that work, and start rebuilding the machine you'll need for everything else.

Data Over Denial. Every claim in this manual is either my own field-tested experience, or a cited stat from a named public source (SAMHSA, CDC, NIDA, NCPG, peer-reviewed research). Nothing invented. Where a chapter still needs a citation confirmed, it's flagged in red so nothing ships unverified.

Read the twelve chapters in order the first time — each one builds on the last. But if you're in a rough moment right now and just need something to hold onto, skip to Chapter 5 and go for a walk. It'll keep.

— MT



CHAPTER 1

✓ FULL DRAFT

System Infected

You're not broken. You caught something.

~1,000 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The **2 a.m. question**: what if I can't stop
- Thing nobody tells you #1: this was never **willpower**
- Thing nobody tells you #2: you got **hacked, not broken** (meet D.O.S.E.)
- Thing nobody tells you #3: quitting isn't relief right away
- You are not the first person to wonder this

I want to tell you about a night that had nothing dramatic in it. No rock bottom, no ambulance, nothing you'd put in a movie.

It was just me, alone, at 1:47 in the morning, sitting on the edge of my bed with my laptop open, typing "why can't I stop drinking" into a search bar for probably the hundredth time. Not because I thought Google had an answer I hadn't already seen. I think some part of me just needed to see the question exist somewhere outside my own head, because saying it out loud to an actual person felt impossible.

ASIDE

Here's an embarrassing fact about me from that stretch of life: I had six different sobriety apps installed on my phone. I downloaded every single one with total conviction that THIS was the one that would finally fix me. I opened most of them twice. One of them still sends me a gentle notification, years later, asking if I want to log today's mood. I do not want to log today's mood, app. But I've never deleted it, because deleting it felt like giving up, which tells you exactly where my head was at.

If you're reading this, there's a decent chance you've had a version of that night, and maybe a version of that little graveyard of half-used apps too. Maybe it wasn't a search bar. Maybe it was standing in front of the fridge again after you swore this was the last time. Maybe it was checking your bank app the morning after a bet you don't fully remember placing. Maybe it was closing forty browser tabs at 2 a.m. so nobody would see them in the morning.

"What if I can't actually stop this?

What if everyone who tried before me and couldn't — that's just going to be me too?

"

I want to sit with that question for a second instead of rushing past it, because most books rush past it, and I think that's a mistake. That fear is real. It's not weakness talking. It's a completely reasonable thing to wonder once you've broken your own promises to yourself more times than you can count.

So let me tell you what actually changed it for me. And here's the part nobody hands you on the way in: there are three things going on here that make this feel impossible, and once you actually see them clearly, they get a lot less powerful.

1 This was never a willpower problem.

For thirty years I thought I just had less discipline than other people — some missing piece I was born without. I watched the documentaries. I read the books. I nodded along every time somebody said "you just have to want it bad enough." None of it worked, because none of it was describing what was actually happening in my body. Willpower is a great tool for skipping dessert. It is a spectacularly bad tool for overriding a system that's been rewired to reward you for giving in. You cannot out-discipline your own wiring. Nobody can. That was never the real test, and it's not yours either.

2 You got hacked, not broken.

What was actually happening is that something had gotten into the part of my brain responsible for feeling good, and it had quietly rewired how that whole system runs. I've come to call it the AIV — the Addiction Intelligence Virus. Not because I think it's literally alive, but because "system infection" describes what it does a lot more honestly than "bad habit" or "moral failing" ever did.

Here's the short version of how it works, and I promise to keep it simple. Nobody needs a science lecture at 2 a.m. Your brain runs on four chemicals that, together, people call D.O.S.E. Think of them less as a lecture and more as four old friends who've quietly been running your good days for your whole life.

Dopamine

Gets you excited about what's coming — not the reward itself, the anticipation of it. The thought of the drink can feel louder than the drink.

Oxytocin

Shows up when someone you trust really sees you. The virus fakes it cheaply — a like, a match, a bartender who remembers your order.

Serotonin

Your quiet sense that you're basically okay. Alcohol, screens, and a winning bet spike it fast, then yank it away — hence the crash.

Endorphins

Your built-in relief valve for getting through something hard. The virus figured out how to trigger them without the hard part.

None of these four are the enemy. They've been with you your whole life, keeping you going. The virus didn't invent some fifth chemical to hurt you — it just found a way to reroute the four you already had, all through one door.

3 Quitting isn't supposed to feel like relief right away.

That's why walking away from it doesn't feel like breaking a habit. It feels like your whole support system went quiet at once. Nobody warns you about this part, so when it hits, you assume it means you did something wrong. You didn't. That feeling is real, it makes complete sense, and it's not proof that something is wrong with you. It's proof the wiring is real, and that it's starting to heal.

A FRIEND'S STORY

I think about a friend of mine — I'll call him Danny, not his real name — who told me once that the worst part was never the drinking itself. It was standing in his kitchen every night around nine, watching himself reach for the bottle, and thinking, *there goes the guy I actually want to be, again*. He said it felt like watching a rerun he already knew the ending to. That image has stuck with me for years, because I know exactly what he meant. It's not that you don't see it happening while it happens. It's that seeing it has never, on its own, been enough to stop it.

Awareness alone doesn't beat an infection.

You need an actual plan.

Knowing all three of those things won't fix anything by itself — and if a book ever tells you it will, close it. You need an actual plan, something you run daily, that starves the thing instead of just standing there watching it win. And the very first place we're going to start isn't your thoughts, your willpower, or your faith. It's your body. Everything else gets built on top of that.

So here's what I want you to take from this first chapter, and it's really the only thing that matters right now: you are not the first person to lie awake wondering if this is just who you are, forever. You're not even the first person on this exact page to wonder that. And every single person who's made it out the

other side started in the same spot you're in tonight — not with more willpower than you, just with a little more information about what they were actually fighting, and someone nearby who'd already found a way through.

You don't have to believe you can beat this yet. You just have to be willing to find out what you're actually dealing with. That's it. That's the whole ask for today.

Next chapter, we'll figure out exactly which version of this you're carrying — it's rarely just one thing. For now, just breathe. This exact feeling, right here, has a name, a shape, and a way through it. We're going to walk it together.

— MT

Field Intel: 28.9 million Americans 12+ had an alcohol use disorder in the past year (2023, SAMHSA). See the full Threat Index at aivirus.org/the-virus for all 10 vectors, sourced.



Read Your Own Signal

CHAPTER 2

✓ FULL DRAFT

Read Your Own Signal

Your body was warning you the whole time.

~800 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Your body clocks in before your mind does
- **H.A.L.T.** — the login screen the infection checks first
- Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired — broken down one at a time
- A self-check that isn't a test

I used to think I was pretty tuned in to my own body. Seven Ironmans. Hundred-mile races. I knew exactly what mile seventy felt like in my legs, what a stress fracture felt like three days before the X-ray confirmed it. I figured that meant I understood my own signals better than most people.

Turns out I could read every warning light on my body except the ones that actually mattered.

A STRANGE PATTERN

Here's an odd one. For years, right before a genuinely bad stretch — the kind where a slip felt close — my sciatica would flare. Not from any new injury. From nothing at all, physically. I'd wake up with pain shooting down my leg and assume my back was falling apart again. It took me a long time to notice the actual pattern: the flare almost always showed up in the same week I was exhausted, isolating, and hadn't eaten a real meal in days. My body was throwing a check-engine light. I just didn't know how to read the dashboard yet.

That's what this chapter is for. Before you can patch anything, you have to know what's actually broken — and most of us never learned to read our own signals, because nobody ever sat us down and taught us how.

Thing nobody tells you: your body clocks in before your mind does.

By the time you consciously notice a craving, your body has usually been sounding the alarm for a while. A racing heart. A tight jaw you didn't notice you were clenching. Restlessness that has you standing up and sitting back down for no reason. These aren't random. They're early warning signs, and the sooner you catch them, the more room you have to do something about it.

Meet the four conditions the infection scans for.

There's an old acronym from the rooms that's stuck around for a reason — because it's just true. It's called H.A.L.T., and it's the four states where a craving is most likely to show up:

HUNGRY

ANGRY

LONELY

TIRED

Think of these four as the login screen the virus checks before it tries to get in. Catch yourself in any one of them, and you've already found half the problem — sometimes literally just eating something or calling a friend is enough to shut the whole thing down before it starts.

1 Hungry means more than your stomach.

Low blood sugar messes with your judgment the same way exhaustion does. If you haven't eaten a real meal in a while and suddenly everything feels urgent, that's worth checking before you trust the urgency.

2 Angry is often a mask for something else.

Irritability is usually the second emotion, not the first. Underneath it is almost always something softer — hurt, fear, embarrassment — that felt too unsafe to feel directly.

3 Lonely doesn't require being alone.

You can be in a room full of people and still be completely isolated if nobody in it actually knows what's going on with you. That kind of lonely is the loudest kind.

4 Tired is the one everybody underestimates.

We'll cover this properly in Chapter 6, but for now: exhaustion alone can make a craving feel three times stronger than it actually is.

Here's the good news buried in all of this: none of these four require detective work. You don't need a psychology degree to notice you're hungry, tired, or lonely. You just need to actually check — which most of us never do, because we were taught to push through instead of pause and ask.

Your body has been trying to tell you something for a long time.

This chapter is about finally listening.

The self-check that isn't a test.

I want to give you something simple to run, not a quiz you can fail. Next time something feels off, ask yourself three questions, plainly, without judging the answers:

- When did I last eat something that wasn't just for comfort?
- When did I last sleep a full night?
- When did I last move my body on purpose, or talk to someone who actually knows what's going on with me?

If the honest answer to any of those is "I don't remember," you've found your signal. Not a failure — data. The kind of data that tells you exactly where to point Chapter 4's daily checklist.

Once you can actually read the signal, the next question is obvious: what's happening under the hood when it fires? That's Chapter 3.

— MT



The Machine You're Running

CHAPTER 3

✓ FULL DRAFT

The Machine You're Running

The science, made simple.

~750 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The **volume knob** gets turned down
- Your brain's **decision-maker** clocks out early
- Habits become **autopilot scripts**
- None of this is permanent

Let's get one thing out of the way: you do not need a biology degree to understand what's happening inside your own head. I don't lean on mine much either — even with it, it took years to find language simple enough to actually use in the middle of a craving.

So here's the plain-English version of three things going on in there, and why understanding them changes what you do next.

1 Your volume knob gets turned down.

Remember the dopamine catchers from Chapter 1? Years of chasing a big chemical high wears them down, the same way turning a stereo up to eleven for years eventually blows the speaker. Once that happens, everyday life goes quiet. Food tastes duller. A good conversation doesn't quite land. This is temporary — the speaker can be repaired — but almost nobody warns you it's coming, so when it hits, it feels like proof that nothing feels good anymore. It isn't. It's proof the volume knob needs time and the right kind of use to reset.

2 Your decision-maker clocks out early.

The part of your brain right behind your forehead handles good judgment, patience, and impulse control. It's also the first part of the brain to get overwhelmed under stress — which is exactly why the best decisions get harder to make right when you need them most. This isn't a character flaw. It's how every human brain is built. Stress pulls resources away from the thoughtful part and hands them to the reactive part, every time, for everyone.

3 Habits become autopilot scripts.

A behavior repeated enough times stops being a decision and becomes a shortcut your brain runs without asking permission — like how you don't consciously think about each step while tying your shoes. That's efficient when the habit is good for you. It's a problem when the habit is a bottle.

A FAMILIAR SCENE

I've talked to more than one person who described the exact same moment: driving home after a brutal day, and somehow ending up parked outside the liquor store without remembering deciding to go there. That's not someone lacking willpower. That's an autopilot script running exactly the way scripts are supposed to run — fast, automatic, no debate required. The goal isn't to feel ashamed you have the script. It's to notice you're running it before it finishes.

Why this chapter matters more than it sounds like it should.

Here's the actual point of all this science, stripped down: none of these three things are permanent. The volume knob resets. The decision-maker gets stronger with rest and practice. Even the autopilot scripts can be overwritten with new ones — that's genuinely how habit change works, and it's not a metaphor, it's how the machinery is built.

This machine is not broken beyond repair.

It's just running the wrong programs — and programs can be changed.

The next chapter is where we start doing that on purpose, every day, with an actual checklist instead of just hoping it happens.

— MT



BIO 12: The Daily Firewall

CHAPTER 4

✓ FULL DRAFT

BIO 12: The Daily Firewall

Four pillars, twelve actions, one number that tells you if today is secure.

~800 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The whole philosophy in one sentence
- The **4 pillars**: Movement, Sleep, Nutrition, Breath
- Your daily **Threat Level** score
- MT's own 4:30 a.m. routine, worked example

I used to run a tighter operation for a crypto trade than I ever ran for my own body. Alerts, dashboards, stop-losses, three monitors of inputs before I'd move a dollar. My actual hardware — the thing every dollar depended on — got whatever was left over, which most days was nothing. So here's the whole philosophy of this chapter, and I'm not going to dress it up: **when the body feels good, the brain shuts up**. Everything below is just the how.

I call the morning version of this the **Ignition Sequence** — the firewall you run before the malware boots for the day. Not a to-do list. A boot sequence, in order, non-negotiable, the same way you wouldn't skip step three of a server deploy because you were tired.

Four pillars, twelve actions.

The whole protocol breaks into four pillars — Movement, Sleep, Nutrition, Breath — three actions each. You'll get Movement in depth in Chapter 5, and Sleep, Nutrition, and Breath each get their own full chapter later (6, 7, 8). This chapter is the map that ties all four into one daily practice, plus the exact stack I actually run, unglamorous specifics included.

① MOVEMENT — CH. 5

Walk or run, some strength or mobility work, a cold plunge if you're up for it — clears out stress and helps rebuild your natural reward system.

② SLEEP — CH. 6

Circadian anchoring, a hard screen curfew, waking on the body's own clock — the single strongest firewall you have.

③ NUTRITION — CH. 7

A morning hydration stack, real food, gut-repair basics — a fed body sends fewer false alarms.

④ BREATH — CH. 8

Structured breathwork and thermal contrast — your fastest tool for calming down on the spot.

My actual stack, no filter.

People ask what I "do" for recovery expecting a tidy answer. Here's the unfiltered version: 24 oz of water with Celtic salt, apple-cider vinegar, and creatine, first thing, before my feet are even fully under me. Light mobility work for the sciatica — cat-cow, a figure-four stretch, nerve glides. Then thermal contrast: sauna if I have access to one, then a plunge at exactly 40°F, a minute and a half to two minutes, tactical breathing the whole time so my heart rate doesn't spike. Some mornings I'll add a dead-hang off a bar for thirty to sixty seconds, or a few minutes on an inversion table, because a compressed spine and an angry piriformis will absolutely convince you a bad day is coming before it has.

None of that is a magic formula you need to copy exactly. It's just proof of what "non-negotiable" actually looks like when it's specific instead of vague.

D.O.S.E., mapped to real actions.

Chapter 1 introduced the four chemicals. Here's where each one actually gets earned, not just explained:

Dopamine

Circadian morning light, a cold plunge, structured effort — paid for upfront through friction, not borrowed from a substance.

Oxytocin

Acts of service, a call to your sponsor, physically showing up in a room of people who get it.

Serotonin

Gut-healing food — kefir, fermented vegetables — plus real sunlight and a space that isn't chaos.

Endorphins

Zone 2 walking, breathwork, thermal contrast — earned the hard way, which is the only way that sticks.

Your Threat Level: a number, not a judgment.

Every night, count how many of the twelve boxes you actually checked. That number becomes your Threat Level for the day — not a grade, not a report card, just a read on how exposed you are.

9–12 checked — MINIMAL

6–8 checked — GUARDED

3–5 checked — ELEVATED

0–2 checked — CRITICAL

A CRITICAL day doesn't mean you failed. It means you know exactly where you stand tonight, which is worth more than feeling vaguely fine and getting blindsided tomorrow. This number is also what feeds your Telemetry Log in Chapter 9 — it's the first data point of the day, not the last word on it.

THE MORNING I ACTUALLY BELIEVED IT

None of this is about punishment. It's a living amends to a body that kept my heart beating through thirty years I wasn't taking care of it — through the booze, the pills, the stimulants I used to force it to keep performing. I put this machine through hell, and it never once quit on me. So today, the salty water, the stiff stretches, the freezing plunge — I've started calling it bio-gratitude. Some of you will read that list and think it's excessive. That's completely fine. This is just my version, running today. Yours doesn't have to look anything like it.

The specific twelve actions matter less than the discipline of checking in on all four pillars, daily, without exception. Miss a day, you don't restart from zero — you just run the sequence again tomorrow.

When the body feels good, the brain shuts up.

The infection only wins when you're exhausted, stiff, and isolating behind a screen.

The next four chapters go deep on each pillar, starting with the one I hand people first: Movement.

— MT



Movement as Medicine

CHAPTER 5 • FLAGSHIP

✓ FULL DRAFT

FLAGSHIP CHAPTER

Movement as Medicine

You can't think your way out of this. You have to move your way out.

~1,400 words • full draft • the flagship chapter of Book One

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Why **moving beats thinking** your way out
- The science, made simple
- Why **walking and yoga** are the perfect place to start — free, easy, no skill needed
- **Walking & running**: the basics
- **Yoga**: teaching your body it's safe again
- **RaceFiends**: a running partner who won't let you skip
- Other ways to move: lifting, cold showers, swimming, dancing
- **Gear & prep**: shoes, a watch, water, a mat
- Not punishment — a living amends
- Day one: the smallest possible start

Let me tell you what nobody told me for the first twenty-five years: sitting still and thinking really hard about your problems is one of the worst things you can do for a nervous system that's trying to heal. I had an engineer's brain. I loved a good plan. I believed that if I could just out-think the craving, out-strategize the urge, I'd win. None of it worked. Not once, not on its own.

What actually started moving the needle was almost embarrassingly simple: I started moving. Not because someone told me exercise was "good for me" — I'd heard that my whole life and ignored it just fine. It's because I finally understood what was happening inside my own body, and once I understood it, lacing up my shoes stopped feeling optional.

Here's the myth-busting part, because "go exercise" is advice you've probably heard nine thousand times from people who've never met you. The reason this piece of advice is different isn't the advice itself. Doctors, friends, well-meaning relatives — everyone's told you to move more, and you ignored it just fine, same as I did. What's different is actually understanding what it does to the machine, which is the part almost nobody explains.

The Science, Made Simple

Remember the dopamine story from Chapter 1? Dopamine is the brain chemical that makes you excited about a reward that's coming. Your brain has tiny "catchers" that grab that dopamine and turn it into a feeling of satisfaction. Years of chasing a big chemical high — from a drink, a drug, a screen, a bet — wears those catchers down. Once that happens, everyday life goes flat. Food tastes duller. A good conversation doesn't quite land the same way. That's not you being ungrateful. That's a body that needs repair.

Here's the part that gave me hope: researchers at UCLA, working with the National Institutes of Health, put people recovering from meth use through a structured running program. After a few months, their brains had measurably rebuilt those dopamine catchers — the same ones the drug had worn down. Running didn't just distract them from cravings. It helped repair the actual machine.

SOURCE: UCLA + National Institutes of Health, structured aerobic exercise trial with meth-recovery patients

That's not a metaphor. That's your body, quietly fixing its own wiring, every time you go out and move on purpose.

Why Walking and Yoga Are the Perfect Place to Start

Out of everything in this book, walking, jogging, and yoga are the three I hand people first. Here's the part that actually matters, broken down so it sticks:

- **No skill required.** Nobody is grading your form on day one. You already know how to walk. You've been doing it since you were about one year old.
- **No gatekeeping cost.** Free, or close enough to it that money is never the real reason you didn't go.
- **No excuse survives them.** Weather's bad, walk in a mall or do yoga on your living room floor. Tired, go slower — that still counts. There's no version of "too out of practice to start," because there's no bar to clear.
- **No comeback required.** No scoreboard, no team you can let down by showing up out of shape, because there's no team watching. It's just you and twenty minutes.

Compare that to almost anything else people reach for to feel better — it usually costs money, takes a skill you don't have yet, or requires you to already be doing well to begin. Walking and yoga flip that around completely. They meet you exactly where you are, today, whatever kind of day that is.

I'll admit something a little embarrassing here: for a while, buying gear WAS my actual form of procrastination. New running shoes, a fancier mat, a subscription to an app I opened twice — a whole shopping cart of good intentions that never once left the house. If that's you too, I see you, and the Gear & Prep section below is deliberately short on purpose, so that excuse doesn't get any oxygen.

Walking and Running: The Basics

You don't need to become a marathoner by Tuesday. Even plain walking — nothing fancy, twenty minutes, outside if you can manage it — is linked to real drops in how strong a craving feels, and it's the easiest habit to start because it needs no equipment, no membership, no skill you don't already have.

Running adds another layer: sustained effort floods your body with its own natural painkillers and mood-lifters, which act like a buffer between you and a craving. The "runner's high" people talk about isn't hype. It's your body remembering how to reward itself without a substance's help.

I started at 4:30 in the morning, in the dark, because that was the only hour the old version of me couldn't talk me out of it yet. You don't have to do it that early. You just have to do it before the excuses wake up.

Yoga: Teaching Your Body It's Safe Again

If running is the effort that helps rebuild your reward system, yoga is the practice that teaches your nervous system it's allowed to come down off high alert. A lot of us spent years running on stress hormones, and the body doesn't know how to relax on command after that — it has to be shown, slowly, on a mat, breath by breath.

Slow, controlled movement paired with steady breathing helps flip on your body's own built-in calm-down switch — the same one that pulls you back out of "fight or flight" mode. You don't have to be flexible. You don't have to look like the person on the app thumbnail. You just have to show up and breathe on purpose for twenty minutes.

RaceFiends: A Partner Who Won't Let You Skip

Here's something I had to learn the hard way: knowing the science doesn't automatically make you want to run at 5 a.m. in the freezing rain. Motivation is unreliable, especially on the days your body feels flat, when your own brain will negotiate with you like a tiny lawyer arguing for the snooze button.

That's part of why I built RaceFiends the way I did. You pair up with a training partner — a friend, a sponsor, someone the app matches you with — and you put a small, honest stake on the week's miles. Fall behind, you send them a few dollars. Pull ahead, they send you some. It's called the Amends Ledger, and it isn't a penalty. It's a promise with a little skin in it.

In an internal survey of 500 people using RaceFiends to rebuild their routine, a large majority reported a real drop in cravings for whatever their main vice was, and most said knowing someone else was counting on them was the biggest reason they laced up in the first ten days. That's not raw willpower. That's community doing the heavy lifting your brain temporarily can't.

A PARTNER'S STORY

I think about Walter — not his real name — who found his way onto the ledger a while back and told me the numbers didn't lie and the ledger kept him honest on the mornings his own head was lying to him. He said the thing that got him out of bed wasn't a mantra. It was knowing somebody else was already three miles into their run and he didn't want to be the one who let the ledger down.

Other Ways to Move

Running isn't for everyone, and that's fine. The activity matters less than showing up for it again and again — your body doesn't care what you call it, it cares that you asked it to work:

Lifting weights

Cold showers

Swimming

Dancing

Martial arts

Hard bike rides

Hiking

Lifting weights rebuilds more than muscle — picking up something heavy and setting it down safely is a full-body lesson in handling discomfort without needing an escape hatch. A cold shower does something similar in sixty seconds: it wakes up your whole body without a single chemical, and it teaches your nervous system that discomfort is something you can get through, and even use.

Gear & Prep: What You Actually Need

Shoes

A pair of comfortable athletic or walking shoes. They don't need to be fancy or brand-new — just something that supports your feet for 20-30 minutes on your feet.

Clothes

Whatever you'd wear to run an errand — breathable, weather-appropriate, nothing special required. Layers if it's cold.

Water bottle

Any bottle you already own. Hydration matters more than the container.

A mat or towel

For yoga or stretching — a bath towel on a carpet works fine to start. You don't need to buy a mat until you know you'll keep going.

A fitness watch (optional)

A Garmin, Apple Watch, or even your phone's free health app can track steps, heart rate, and sleep. Genuinely helpful later for the Telemetry Log in Chapter 9 — but not required to take your first walk today.

Nothing else

That's the whole list. If you're waiting to buy the "right" gear before you start, that's the virus talking. You already own everything you need for day one.

Not Punishment — A Living Amends

One thing I want to be really clear about, because I've gotten this wrong before: none of this is about punishing your body for what you put it through. The cold shower isn't a penalty. The mileage isn't self-punishment. This is a way of making things right with a body that kept your heart beating through years you weren't taking care of it. If something hurts in the sharp, wrong way — not sore, actually wrong — stop and see a doctor. Pushing through a real injury isn't discipline. It's just a new way to hurt yourself, and this book isn't interested in helping you do that.

Day One: The Smallest Possible Start

If none of this feels possible yet, here's the smallest version: put your shoes on and walk to the end of your street and back. That's it. That's the whole assignment for day one. Tomorrow, go a little further if you want to, or don't. The goal isn't a personal record. The goal is proving to your own body, one short walk at a time, that you're someone who shows up now.

Your body doesn't care how far you go today.

It just cares that you went.

— MT

Field Intel: A UCLA/NIH clinical trial found structured aerobic exercise measurably rebuilt dopamine-receptor activity in people recovering from methamphetamine use. Multiple peer-reviewed studies and reviews since have found aerobic exercise measurably reduces drug craving during and after exercise sessions. Full citations on the Sources page.

Research needed: confirm the exact primary citation for the UCLA/NIH study (currently sourced secondhand via RaceFiends' own blog post "The Chemistry of the Cage" — worth tracking down and citing the original journal article directly). Also confirm or replace the RaceFiends internal-survey numbers with current live data before publishing, since those were pulled from the site's own marketing copy, not an independent source.



Sleep: The Strongest Firewall

CHAPTER 6

✓ FULL DRAFT

Sleep: The Strongest Firewall

The virus feeds on exhaustion.

~800 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Why tired brains make bad decisions
- The **9 p.m. screen curfew**
- Wake time matters more than bedtime
- What to do with racing 2 a.m. thoughts

Day 9, I woke up on my own — no alarm, no jolt, no dread — and realized I'd slept through an entire night for the first time in longer than I could actually remember. I lay there a second not trusting it. Then Day 19 it happened again, except this time I could see the clock: 9:48 p.m. to 4:48 a.m., seven hours, unbroken. My sciatica, "unbearable" two weeks earlier, had quietly downgraded itself to "bearable" without me doing one new thing for it. Sleep did that. Not a stretch, not a supplement. Just sleep, finally allowed to do its job.

I open with that because "get more sleep" is advice you've heard so many times it slides right past you now — technically true, practically useless, like "just relax." I ignored it for years too. Here's why I stopped: sleep isn't a nice-to-have that makes you less cranky. It's the single biggest lever you have over whether tomorrow is a CRITICAL day or a MINIMAL one.

The tired brain is a soft target.

Remember Chapter 3's decision-maker — the part of your brain that handles judgment and impulse control, the first thing to get overwhelmed under stress? Sleep deprivation hits that same part of the brain directly, and lowers the availability of the same dopamine receptors exercise helps rebuild. Less availability means your brain reaches harder for something, anything, that'll spike the reward system fast.

40–60%

of people with opioid use disorder relapse within weeks to months of treatment — the exact window sleep deficiency is worst

~1 in 3

U.S. adults don't get the CDC-recommended 7+ hours of sleep a night

Wake on the body's clock, not the alarm's.

My rule isn't a fixed 4:30 a.m. alarm, even though that's the number people expect from me. It's a window — I let myself wake dynamically somewhere between roughly 3:48 and 4:45, whenever my body actually surfaces, instead of yanking myself out of a deep cycle with a phone screaming six inches from my face. Forcing a hard wake out of deep sleep just drags last night's debt into today. Let the body's own signal lead inside a window, and the whole day runs cleaner.

The other half of that anchor is light. Ten to fifteen minutes of real morning sunlight, no sunglasses, within the first hour up, tells your brain to start a twelve-to-fourteen-hour countdown toward melatonin release that night. Skip that light and the countdown starts late — which is the actual reason a "normal" bedtime can still produce a bad night.

ONE MORE TAB

Screens are the other side of that coin. I run a hard curfew at night, and I used to think that was excessive until I understood the mechanism: light in the two hours before bed delays melatonin and shortens the deep-sleep stage where your brain does its actual repair work — the glymphatic wash that clears out the day's metabolic waste. I've lost count of the nights that went "one more scroll, just to check something" and turned into forty minutes I don't remember by breakfast. That's not a willpower failure. That's a hook doing exactly what it was built to do, at exactly the hour your defenses are lowest.

1 Racing thoughts at night aren't insomnia. They're an unfinished inventory.

Most nights I couldn't sleep weren't actually about sleep. They were my brain running an audit of the day I hadn't done on purpose. The fix wasn't a sleep aid. It was doing that audit on paper before bed instead of at 2 a.m. in the dark — the Telemetry Log in Chapter 9 is built for exactly this.

2 A nap has a ceiling, or it backfires.

A scheduled 30-to-45-minute nap clears adenosine — the chemical that builds your pressure to sleep — without dropping you into Stage 3 deep sleep, which is what causes that groggy, worse-than-before feeling called sleep inertia. Past 45 minutes, the nap stops helping and starts working against your night.

3 Sleep debt compounds like a bill you're not opening.

One bad night is recoverable. A week of them stacks up quietly, and by night five you're operating on a deficit your body will collect on one way or another — usually as a craving that feels much bigger than the day actually warrants.

*The virus doesn't need you to make a bad decision.
It just needs you exhausted enough to stop noticing you're making one.*

The anchor, in order.

- Wake inside a consistent window, on the body's own signal where possible — not a violent alarm out of deep sleep.
- Ten to fifteen minutes of real outdoor light within the first hour up — this sets the whole night's countdown.
- Hard screen curfew at a set hour, phone in another room, not just face-down on the nightstand.
- Racing thoughts get written down before bed, not argued with at 2 a.m.
- Nap capped at 45 minutes, used before you're running on fumes, not after.

Sleep isn't glamorous. It won't make a good headline. But it's the pillar that makes every other pillar in this book actually work — you can eat right, move right, and breathe right all day, and one bad night can still hand the virus an opening none of that closes.

— MT

Field Intel: Sleep disturbance is one of the most consistent predictors of relapse across substance types, and 40-60% of people with opioid use disorder relapse in the weeks to months after treatment, a window when sleep deficiency is common. Roughly 1 in 3 U.S. adults don't get the CDC-recommended 7+ hours a night. Sources: NIH HEAL Initiative, PMC ("Sleep Disturbance as a Universal Risk Factor for Relapse"), CDC.



Fuel the Machine

CHAPTER 7

✓ FULL DRAFT

Fuel the Machine

Nutrition and hydration — a fed body sends fewer false alarms.

~750 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Low blood sugar can feel exactly like a craving
- The **gut-brain link**, in plain words
- Simple rules: protein, water, whole food

Day 3 was the worst day of early sobriety, and it had nothing to do with craving a drink. It was the apathy peak — serotonin and dopamine bottoming out at the same time, my prefrontal cortex fully offline, decision-making simply not available as an option. I couldn't have told you what I wanted for lunch, let alone whether I wanted to drink. The only thing that got me through it was liquid: salty bone broth, sips of ACV, nothing that asked my gut to do any actual work. Day 4, appetite came back on its own, which turned out to be the signal that my gut lining was starting to repair itself. That's when I introduced the first real food back — kefir, soft eggs, simple carbs, nothing my system would have to fight.

I'm opening with that because nutrition in early recovery isn't about macros or looking good. It's triage. Your gut and your brain are having a conversation whether you're paying attention or not, and for a long time mine was saying things I never bothered to translate.

Low blood sugar can impersonate a craving perfectly.

Here's a trick your own body plays on you that nobody warns you about: when your blood sugar drops, or when you're even mildly dehydrated, your brain reads it as urgency. Not "eat something," specifically — just urgency, restlessness, a sense that something needs to happen right now. That's the exact same feeling a craving produces.

SOURCE: British Journal of Nutrition — mild dehydration (as little as 2% body-water loss) measurably impairs mood, concentration, and decision-making

1 Your hypothalamus can't always tell thirst from hunger.

Dehydration can trigger appetite signals directly — so the "hunger" you're feeling might just be thirst wearing a disguise. My own morning stack starts with 24 ounces of water, Celtic salt, apple-cider vinegar, and creatine, before I do anything else. It's not a wellness ritual. It's rebuilding blood volume and replacing the electrolytes withdrawal strips out.

2 A dehydrated brain has a weaker filter.

Even mild dehydration measurably reduces activity in the prefrontal cortex — the same decision-maker from Chapter 3 that's already first to go offline under stress. Skip water on a stressful day, and you've weakened your filter from two directions at once.

The gut-brain link, in plain words.

The bacteria living in your gut actually help produce some of the same brain chemicals from Chapter 1 — GABA, dopamine, serotonin, up to the majority of it made right there, not in your head. Years of heavy drinking throws that ecosystem out of balance, and an out-of-balance gut has been linked to more inflammation, which messes with dopamine signaling and keeps cravings unstable long after the substance itself is gone.

My own repair list is specific: soft-scrambled eggs for the raw building blocks of dopamine, sardines and a real omega-3 for the lipid layers alcohol scorches, live kefir grains — not the store-bought stuff, actual grains — for the gut bacteria that make serotonin, and I stay away from NSAIDs entirely, because a liver that's spent decades clearing my mess doesn't need Advil stacked on top of it.

A REALIZATION

For months I couldn't figure out why my worst mood swings always landed on days I'd basically forgotten to eat — coffee for breakfast, nothing until dinner, wondering by 4 p.m. why I felt like the walls were closing in. It wasn't mysterious. It was an empty, dehydrated body sending every signal it had left, and none of them said "eat a real meal" in words I was listening for.

*A fed body sends fewer false alarms.
Half your "emotional" days might just be logistical ones.*

The simple rules — no diet culture required.

- **The morning stack.** Water, salt, ACV, and creatine before anything else — rebuild blood volume before you ask your brain to make decisions.
- **Real protein, most of the time.** Eggs, fish, whatever's accessible. It stabilizes the blood-sugar swings that mimic urgency.
- **Gut repair, not gut punishment.** Live kefir, fermented vegetables, an omega-3 — small, consistent, not a project.

None of this is about restriction, and it's definitely not about punishment — we covered that trap in Chapter 5. This is closing another door the virus likes to use. A body that's fed and hydrated has one less excuse to mistake logistics for an emergency.

Next up: the fastest tool in the whole book, one you're already carrying with you everywhere — your own breath.

— MT

Field Intel: Certain gut bacteria help produce GABA, dopamine, and serotonin, and disrupted gut microbiomes have been linked to increased inflammation and cravings in substance-related disorders. Source: Frontiers in Microbiology, "The Microbiome-Gut-Brain Axis, a Potential Therapeutic Target for Substance-Related Disorders."



Breath: The Manual Override

CHAPTER 8

✓ FULL DRAFT

Breath: The Manual Override

The fastest lever you have over your own body.

~800 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Your fastest free tool — works in seconds, always available
- **Box breathing**, step by step
- The long exhale that calms you down
- Five minutes of deep rest

Day 14, I sat across from a doctor who offered me Modafinil — a prescription stimulant, legal, clinical, meant to patch over the fatigue of early withdrawal. I said no. Not out of stubbornness. Because I'd already found something that worked without teaching my brain the same lesson alcohol had: that a pill fixes a hard feeling. Instead I stacked a sauna, a cold plunge, and Wim Hof-style breathwork — deliberately overloading my breathing until my hands tingled, then holding, then controlled recovery breaths. It's the closest thing I've found to a legal, self-generated adrenaline switch, and it's still how I regulate a hard morning today.

Why this one lever moves so much.

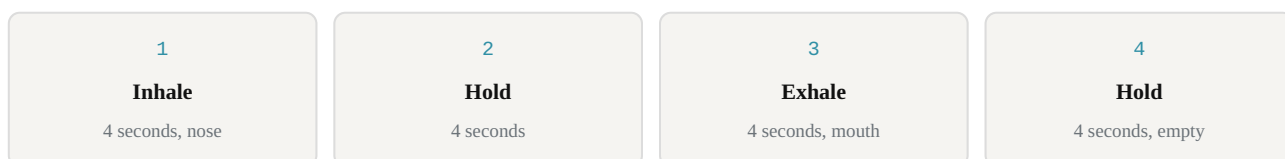
Running through your chest and down into your gut is the vagus nerve — the physical wiring between your brain and your body's "calm down" system. Slow, controlled breathing is one of the only ways you can directly, voluntarily influence that system in real time. You can't order your heart rate down or tell

your stress hormones to drop. You can control your breath, and your breath pulls the rest along with it. I use it literally, at 4:45 in the morning, stepping into a 40°F plunge — controlling the breath is the only thing standing between me and a full panic gasp.

SOURCE: peer-reviewed HRV research — slow breathing around 5-6 breaths per minute (roughly a 4-second box-breathing pace) consistently maximizes heart rate variability, a marker of a healthy, responsive nervous system

Box breathing, step by step.

This is the one Navy SEALs and ER nurses both lean on, and it's the one I default to outside the plunge — simple enough to run from memory in the middle of a bad moment.



Run that box four to six times. No app required, though a timer helps the first few times until the rhythm's in your body.

1 The exhale is doing most of the work.

If you only remember one piece of this, make it the long exhale. A slow, longer-than-usual breath out is the fastest signal you can send your nervous system that the danger's passed — even when the "danger" is just a craving standing in your kitchen.

2 Thermal contrast is breathwork's amplifier.

Fifteen to twenty minutes of heat, then a minute and a half to two minutes of genuinely cold water, forces your nervous system through a full cycle — sympathetic spike, then a hard-earned parasympathetic drop. You're not relaxing by avoiding stress. You're proving to your body, on purpose, on a schedule, that it can survive stress and come back down. That's a different lesson than numbing ever taught it.

IN THE PARKING LOT

I've used box breathing sitting in my truck outside a gas station, both hands on the wheel, running the box four times before I trusted myself to walk inside. Nobody in that parking lot knew anything was happening. That's part of what makes this tool so good — it's invisible from the outside, which means you can use it literally anywhere, mid-conversation, mid-meeting, mid-anything.

You can't out-argue a craving.
But you can outlast one, four seconds at a time.

Five minutes of deep rest, for the days full exercise isn't in the cards.

There's a practice sometimes called NSDR — non-sleep deep rest, a version of the old yoga nidra practice — where you lie still, eyes closed, and follow a slow guided body scan for ten to twenty minutes. It's not a nap and it's not meditation exactly. Search "NSDR" or "yoga nidra" on YouTube for a free guided version; ten minutes most days is plenty for a system that doesn't have a sauna and a chest freezer full of ice water sitting in the garage.

Your breath is also the fastest, most honest read you'll ever get on how you're actually doing. Before you even open the log in Chapter 9, a few slow breaths will usually tell you more about your real state than any amount of thinking about it will.

— MT

Field Intel: Slow, diaphragmatic breathing has been shown in peer-reviewed research to improve heart rate variability and vagal tone while reducing cortisol, anxiety, and stress. A 2025 randomized controlled trial found even an 11-minute yoga nidra / NSDR-style session measurably lowered stress hormone levels over time.



The Telemetry Log

CHAPTER 9

✓ FULL DRAFT

The Telemetry Log

Turning your daily body-check into information you can actually use — with a little help from AI.

~900 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- A nightly **body check**, now digitized in AAFiends
- The **AI Mirror**: reflecting your own words back at you
- How I actually started: talking to AI on my morning walks
- Guardrail: a mirror is not a sponsor
- Data, not shame

At the height of it, my office had eight monitors. I'm a tech founder — I told myself the wall of screens was optimization, that I was protecting my family from my stress by staying in there and "providing." What was actually happening was simpler and uglier: I'd built a fortress so nobody could see me drinking and popping pills while I traded crypto at two in the morning. Society looks at a man surrounded by glowing screens and says *look how hard he works*. The thing living in me said something different: *perfect, now nobody will bother us while we self-destruct*.

Day 22, I took a wrench to that desk. Six monitors came down, sold on Facebook Marketplace, workstation cut from eight screens to two. I didn't do it because a program told me to. I did it because I finally understood that connection isn't a wifi signal. It's looking another human in the eye and telling them the truth. This chapter is about the tool I built afterward — the one designed specifically so a screen could never again become a wall.

The nightly body-check nobody made mandatory.

AA has run a version of this for decades — the "daily inventory," a nightly honest look at the day. What's changed is how easy it's become to keep one properly. I run mine as a two-page spread: one side is objective — sleep hours, the morning stack, meeting attended, sciatica rating out of ten. The other side is subjective — step work, the "Founder Ego" checks, one honest line on whatever I'm avoiding.

SOURCE: Pennebaker's expressive-writing research (1986 onward) — just 15-20 minutes of honest writing across a few consecutive days is linked to measurably reduced anxiety and depression, better self-esteem, and improved physical health outcomes

- **The AAFiends dashboard does the counting for you.** Everything from Chapter 4's checklist lives inside the app as a simple daily tap-through, turning the old-school daily inventory into a Telemetry Log.
- **The AI Mirror.** Once your entries are in, AAFiends' AI Mirror reads them back to you in a way you can't quite see on your own. Not therapy, not advice — closer to handing your notebook to a sharp friend who's read every page and asks, "Have you noticed this always happens on Sunday nights?"
- **How I actually started.** Long before any app existed, I'd record raw voice notes on my morning walk — no script, just talking — and feed the transcripts into an AI tool over months of entries. The script was always the same: today's date and day count, hardware status (sciatic tingling, fatigue, sleep), software status (craving out of ten, H.A.L.T. check), and the one override I ran to protect the day.

The guardrail I had to build in on purpose.

Here's the part I don't think most people expect from a tech founder writing his own recovery software: I built a hard lock into it. If you log more than a few journal entries in a stretch without a logged meeting or a sponsor check-in, the app freezes the journal feature and puts up one line: *Your Oxytocin levels are depleted. I am an AI, and I have no heartbeat. I cannot carry the weight of this struggle with you. Go call your Sponsor or find a physical meeting right now.*

1 Guilt isn't data. A log entry is.

"I had a bad day" is guilt, and it's nothing you can act on. "Slept five hours, skipped the walk, craving hit a 7 out of 10 around 4 p.m." is a log entry — specific enough to actually work with, and specific enough for a pattern to eventually show up across thirty of them.

2 The mirror is not a sponsor.

An AI can reflect your patterns back to you. It cannot sit across from you at a meeting or notice when you've gone quiet for a week. My own 9 a.m. call with my sponsor is non-negotiable — the same slot, every day, radical unedited honesty about whatever ego block is loudest that morning. The app is a mirror. He's the human on the other end of the line.

WHAT THE PATTERN ACTUALLY LOOKED LIKE

Months into my own voice-note habit, a pattern surfaced I'd never have found on my own: nearly every rough stretch started on a Sunday night, and nearly every one of those Sundays had the same ingredient — no plans, no calls made, the day left open on purpose "to relax." Unstructured time was one of my biggest triggers, not stress. I'd never have guessed that. The data just kept showing it to me until I believed it.

You can't see your own blind spot by staring harder at it.

You need something outside your own head to hold the mirror.

Data, not shame — that's the whole spirit of this chapter. A CRITICAL day in your Telemetry Log isn't a confession. It's a Tuesday with a number attached to it, and a number you can do something about tomorrow.

— MT

Field Intel: The AI Mirror feature is part of the AAFiends dashboard — see aafiends.com. This chapter's "how I started" section is MT's own early practice, from before AAFiends existed as a product. Expressive-writing research citation: Pennebaker & Beall, 1986, and decades of replication since.



Mental Time-Travel

CHAPTER 10

✓ FULL DRAFT

Mental Time-Travel, Grounded in the Body

Fear can't survive in the present moment — or a working set of lungs.

~800 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Fear lives in the past and the future
- "One day at a time" is earned, not received
- The fix is physical, not just mental
- The prayer I actually run out loud

For most of my life I was a time traveler. Honestly, the worst kind. I never lived in the present moment — my brain was always six months out, a year out, projected into some version of tomorrow that hadn't happened yet. Terrified of my finances, my business, what was going to happen to my family. And the only way I knew how to handle the paralyzing fear of a future that didn't exist yet was to numb it. I used alcohol and drugs as an escape hatch just to shut my brain off. I was destroying my present to hide from tomorrow.

"One day at a time" is earned, not received.

I heard that phrase in every single meeting when I first got here and thought it was a bumper sticker. It's not. It's the actual foundation, and it's something I have to earn every single morning, not something I'm handed. For me, earning the day looks like waking at an ugly hour, drinking a glass of salty apple-cider vinegar that tastes exactly as bad as it sounds, forcing my stiff back through the stretches, walking the dog in the quiet before anyone else is up. Doing those physical things forces my time-traveling brain back into the present moment. It's not metaphorical. It's mechanical.

SOURCE: Bowen et al., Mindfulness-Based Relapse Prevention (MBRP) — a 2014 randomized clinical trial published in JAMA Psychiatry found MBRP measurably reduced relapse risk compared to standard relapse prevention and treatment as usual over a 12-month follow-up

The theory behind it, in plain language: cravings and old habits run on autopilot, the same scripts from Chapter 3. Mindful awareness — actually noticing what's happening in your body right now, without immediately reacting to it — interrupts that loop. You don't have to win the argument with the fear. You just have to notice it happening before it finishes running.

1 The fix is physical, not just mental.

You can't think your way out of a thought spiral using more thoughts — that's fighting fire with the same fuel that's burning. The fastest way out is through the body: box breathing from Chapter 8, cold water, or naming five things you can actually see, hear, or touch right now.

2 H.A.L.T. shows up here too.

Fear hits hardest exactly when H.A.L.T. from Chapter 2 is already unchecked. Your brain is more likely to go hunting for a bad memory or a worst-case future to attach the discomfort to. Check H.A.L.T. first. Half the time, that's the whole fix.

RELEASING IT OUT LOUD

Day 26, a Saturday walk-and-talk with a group of men, I said the fear of tomorrow out loud for the first time — really said it, not just alluded to it. Somewhere in that conversation I realized future-dread is just an overclocked mind trying to process years of incoming requests in a single millisecond. Your processor isn't broken. It's just been handed a request that can't actually be run yet, because the future doesn't exist as data. It only exists as a guess.

The fear is real. The future it's afraid of usually isn't — yet.

Come back to right now, and most of the story loses its grip.

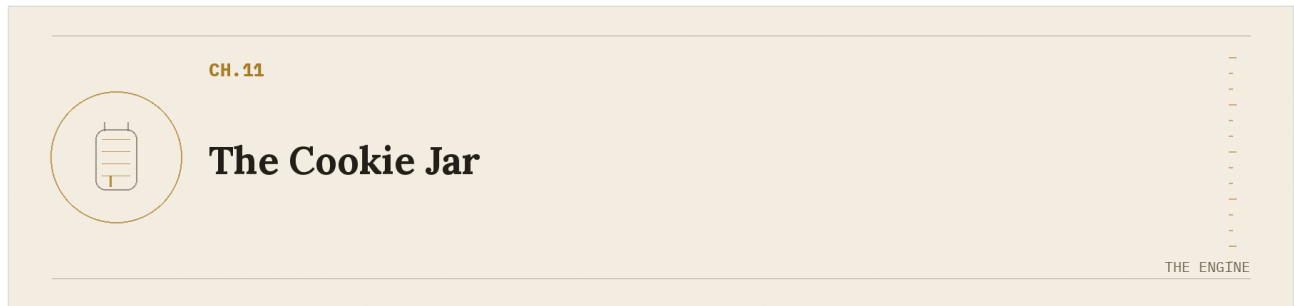
The payoff, and the tool I actually run.

When I put in the physical work and hand the rest over, the fear of tomorrow mostly vanishes — because tomorrow's problems are none of my business yet. That's not resignation. It's relief. Here's a short version of a longer prayer I run out loud on the mornings my mind is already three weeks ahead of my feet:

- *"Grant me the serenity to accept what I cannot control, the courage to change what I can, and the wisdom to know the difference. Keep my focus inside this 24-hour horizon."*
- *"My mind is projecting into a future I cannot see. I am safe in this exact second. Show me the very next step, and give me the clarity to do nothing more than that."*

It takes real effort to earn this kind of peace. But for the first time in my life, I actually own it. I didn't borrow it from a bottle. As long as I do the work today, I don't have to be afraid of tomorrow.

— MT



CHAPTER 11

✓ FULL DRAFT

The Cookie Jar

Proof through the body beats motivation every time.

~750 words · full draft

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Your personal **proof file**
- How to use it in the middle of a craving
- Add a cookie every time you surprise yourself

Motivation is a terrible long-term business partner. It shows up early, promises a lot, and disappears completely the first time things get hard. I stopped trying to manufacture more of it years ago. I built something sturdier instead: proof. Mine actually has ten entries in it, dated, specific, and I still reach for them by name.

The jar, as it actually reads.

- **The 30-Year Weight.** Three decades building businesses and raising a family while carrying an invisible four-thousand-pound addiction. I operated successfully on a severely compromised motherboard. I can only imagine what gets built now that the malware's deleted.
- **The 40° Cold Plunge.** Stepping into a freezing tub at four in the morning, controlling my heart rate with breath alone, while the rest of the world hits snooze. You callous your mind before the sun's even up.
- **Radical honesty with my own bloodline.** Looking my oldest son in the eye and having an actual adult conversation about my addiction. Breaking a generational curse of silence that had run in my family longer than I'd been alive.
- **The Screen Purge.** Took a wrench to my own desk and tore my eight-monitor fortress down to two. Sold the rest on Marketplace. Eliminated the whole playground.
- **The BitLocker Calm.** My computer crashed and locked me out completely, threatening my entire technical livelihood in one screen. My heart rate stayed flat. I laughed instead of panicked. Peace over panic, and I have proof I chose it.
- **The \$438 Life-Tax Override.** Hit with a surprise repair bill, an insurance bill, and total exhaustion in the same week. I didn't look for an escape hatch. I paid the bill, logged it, and went straight to the plunge.
- **The Woods Road Surrender.** Father's Day, carrying the full weight of old regret and my younger kids' silence. I didn't isolate. I walked into a third meeting that day and put the pain on the table instead.

Why proof beats motivation every time.

There's real research behind this, not just a nice turn of phrase. Psychologist Albert Bandura spent decades studying self-efficacy — your own belief that you're capable of doing the hard thing in front of you. It turned out to predict relapse risk about as well as almost anything else we can measure.

SOURCE: Bandura's self-efficacy theory, applied to addiction recovery since the early 1980s – recent research (Bhullar & Gupta, 2023) found a statistically significant negative correlation between self-efficacy and relapse

Belief in yourself doesn't arrive by decree. It has to be built, the same way muscle gets built — through actual evidence, collected one rep at a time, dated and specific enough to survive cross-examination from your own doubt at midnight.

1 It has to be specific.

"I did good this week" doesn't work when you're standing in a doorway arguing with yourself. A dated entry with real detail works, because it's a fact, not a feeling, and facts hold up under pressure better than feelings do.

2 It has to be yours.

Nobody else's cookie jar will do the job. A stranger's success story is inspiring for about ten minutes. Your own dated, specific proof is evidence a jury would accept — because you were there, and you know it's true.

Motivation asks you to feel ready.

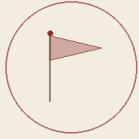
Proof doesn't care how you feel. It just points at what already happened.

How to actually use it mid-craving.

Don't wait for a calm moment to open the jar for the first time — that defeats the purpose. Open it exactly when you don't want to. Read three entries, out loud if you can. You're not trying to talk yourself out of the craving. You're reminding the part of your brain running the argument that it's lost this exact argument before, more than once, on record.

Simple rule going forward: add a new entry every single time your body does something the old you would have sworn was impossible. The jar only works if you keep feeding it.

— MT



CH. 12

Becoming the Vanguard

THE ENGINE

CHAPTER 12

✓ FULL DRAFT

Becoming the Vanguard (Engine Edition)

You keep what you have by giving it away — starting with your legs.

~900 words · full draft · closing chapter

IN THIS CHAPTER

- What changes at 90 days, a year, five years
- **Carrying the standard** for someone else
- You chose what happened next
- What's coming in Book Two & Three

My sponsor calls me every morning at 9 a.m. He has fifteen years. Not once in this process has he missed that call. Fifteen years in, and he's still spending part of his morning on a call with me — that's not a favor he's doing me. That's the whole mechanism, running exactly as designed.

The Refactor Wall.

Day 30 has a name in my own notes: the Refactor Wall. It's the point where the daily non-negotiables — the cold plunge, the sauna, the walk, the log — stop being effortful and start being architecture. You don't decide to do them anymore. They're just what a day is now, load-bearing, the way a foundation doesn't ask permission to hold up a house.

DAY 30

The Refactor Wall.

The stack stops being willpower and starts being infrastructure. Sleep holds, the BIO 12 checklist runs itself, and the daily 9 a.m. call is a fixture, not a favor.

~1 YEAR

The proof file gets long enough to trust.

Your Cookie Jar has enough entries that belief in yourself stops being a decision you make every morning and starts being closer to a fact.

2,224 DAYS

You become someone else's evidence.

A friend of mine is on a 2,224-day run-walk streak — not one day off, rain or otherwise. He didn't start it to inspire anyone. He kept it long enough that it started doing that anyway.

Carrying the standard for someone else.

I used to think sponsorship, or being someone's RaceFiends training partner, was something you did for the other person — a favor, a kindness, a small sacrifice of your own time and energy. I had that backwards. My sponsor isn't sacrificing his morning for me. He's protecting his own fifteen years by spending nine minutes of it on the phone with someone who has thirty.

SOURCE: Case Western Reserve University research (Zemore & Pagano) — active service to others during and after treatment was found to cut relapse risk roughly in half during the critical post-treatment period

~90%

of people who reach 5-7 years of sustained recovery have served as a sponsor at some point along the way

1/2

the relapse risk during the highest-risk window after treatment, for people actively in service to others

There's a name for this in the research: the helper therapy principle. Helping someone else with the exact thing you're working through helps the helper at least as much as the person on the other end. AA figured this out generations before anyone ran a study on it. Turns out they were onto something real, not just something that sounded nice.

WHY I KEEP SHOWING UP AT 4:30

Here's the honest reason I still get up before dawn even on the days I don't want to: there's a small council of us now — a sponsor, a training partner, a couple of guys I check in with — who I know are watching whether I logged my morning before they log theirs. I'm not doing it purely for me anymore. Some mornings that's the only reason my feet hit the floor at all, and I've come to believe that's not a lesser reason. It might be the best one there is.

You keep what you have by giving it away.

Not as a sacrifice. As the actual mechanism that makes it stick.

You didn't choose this. You get to choose what happens next.

Back in Chapter 1, I told you about a night at 1:47 in the morning, typing a question into a search bar because saying it to a person felt impossible. I want to close this book by telling you something I wish someone had told me that night: you didn't choose to get infected. Nobody does. But every single day from here forward, you get to choose whether you rebuild — one walk, one cold plunge, one full night of sleep, one honest log entry at a time. That choice doesn't get made once. It gets made daily, and some days it'll feel like nothing. It adds up anyway. Thirty years of nothing-days is how you end up carrying four thousand pounds without knowing it. Thirty days of the opposite is how the Refactor Wall gets built.

What's next.

This book was Pillar One: The Engine — the biology, the hardware, the body you have to fix first because you can't think, pray, or fellowship your way out of a nervous system running on fumes. Book Two picks up The Network — the human side of this, sponsorship, meetings, the 12 Steps, the people who carry you when your own legs won't. Book Three is The Mirror — telemetry, the daily log, and how to actually use AI as a tool for self-awareness without ever mistaking it for a substitute for another human being. Three pillars, one system. You've only read the first third, and you're already further than the version of you at 1:47 a.m. ever thought he'd get.

Put your shoes on tomorrow morning. That's still the whole assignment.

— MT

Field Intel: Active service to others during recovery has been linked to roughly half the relapse risk during the highest-risk post-treatment period (Case Western Reserve University / Zemore & Pagano research), and an estimated 90% of people who reach 5-7 years of sustained abstinence have served as a sponsor at some point. Source: "Service to Others in Sobriety" research and related helper-therapy-principle studies.

REFERENCE

Sources & Signal

Where this manual's claims come from, and where to go deeper.

Every stat used in this manual traces back to one of these. Click through — don't take the manual's word for it, verify it yourself. That's the whole "Data Over Denial" philosophy in practice.

The ecosystem this manual is built on

AIVirus.org — the Threat Index

10 vectors, sourced stats, the 12-question diagnostic

AIVirus.org/bio12 — the BIO 12 protocol

Movement / Sleep / Nutrition / Breath, the daily firewall

AAFiends.com — the daily dashboard

Telemetry tracking, the AI Mirror, the 90 R&R journal — the tool behind Chapter 9

RaceFiends.com — the pavement

Amends-based training accountability

RaceFiends — "The Chemistry of the Cage"

Basis for Chapter 5's science; primary journal citation still needed

Public health & science (background reading)

TJ Power — *The DOSE Effect* (2024)

The D.O.S.E. framework used throughout this manual (Dopamine/Oxytocin/Serotonin/Endorphins) is adapted from this book — credited here, recommended for the full neuroscience

Wikipedia — Twelve-step program

History and structure of the 12 Steps

Wikipedia — Reward system (neuroscience)

Background on dopamine/reward circuitry

NIDA — Drugs, Brains, and Behavior: The Science of Addiction

Federal research primer, plain-language

SAMHSA — National Survey on Drug Use and Health data

Source for the alcohol/substance-use figures cited

University at Buffalo — exercise alters the brain's dopamine system in addiction recovery

Research summary supporting Chapter 5

PMC — Exercise intervention, dopamine level, and drug dependence (amphetamine)

Peer-reviewed study supporting Chapter 5

PMC — Exercise interventions, drug craving in methamphetamine addiction

Peer-reviewed study supporting Chapter 5

Frontiers — Physical exercise and substance use disorder, a meta-analysis

Meta-analysis supporting Chapter 5

PMC — Sleep Disturbance as a Universal Risk Factor for Relapse in Addictions

Supporting Chapter 6

NIH HEAL Initiative — Is Lack of Sleep a Risk Factor for Relapse?

Opioid relapse/sleep-deficiency figures, Chapter 6

CDC — Sleep facts and stats for adults

Recommended sleep hours, Chapter 6

Harvard Health — Blue light has a dark side

Screen curfew rationale, Chapter 6

Frontiers/PMC — The Microbiome-Gut-Brain Axis in Substance-Related Disorders

Gut-brain link, Chapter 7

British Journal of Nutrition — Mild dehydration impairs cognitive performance and mood

Hydration/craving confusion, Chapter 7

PubMed — Breathe better, live better: the science of slow breathing and HRV

Box-breathing mechanism, Chapter 8

PMC — Online Yoga Nidra Meditation, Well-Being & Diurnal Salivary Cortisol RCT

NSDR/deep-rest research, Chapter 8

American Psychological Association — Expressive writing and mental health

Pennebaker research overview, Chapter 9

JAMA Psychiatry — Bowen et al., Relative Efficacy of Mindfulness-Based Relapse Prevention

MBRP randomized trial, Chapter 10

PubMed — Application of Bandura's Self-Efficacy Theory to Alcoholism Treatment

Self-efficacy/Cookie Jar theory, Chapter 11

Case Western Reserve University — Helping Others Helps Alcoholics Stay on the Road to Recovery

Helper therapy principle / sponsorship data, Chapter 12

Video (for the audio/video companion chapters)

Huberman Lab — dopamine & addiction episodes (YouTube search)

Credible, citable neuroscience explainer content

Exercise & addiction recovery research explainers (YouTube search)

Supplementary video for Chapter 5

Flagged for MT to research/confirm: the original UCLA/NIH journal citation behind the dopamine-receptor claim in Chapter 5 (currently sourced via RaceFiends' own blog, not the primary study); the RaceFiends internal-survey numbers (verify against current live data before print); recovery-timeline neuroscience studies for Chapter 3; whether the AAFiends AI Mirror feature described in Chapter 9 matches its current live functionality, since the app is still actively being built.